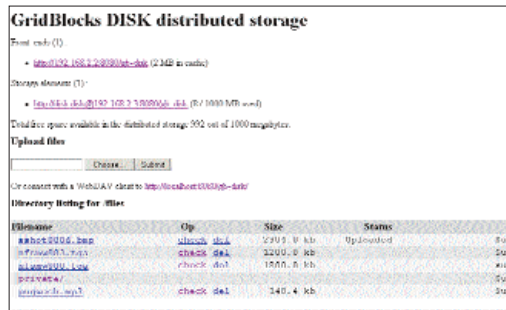
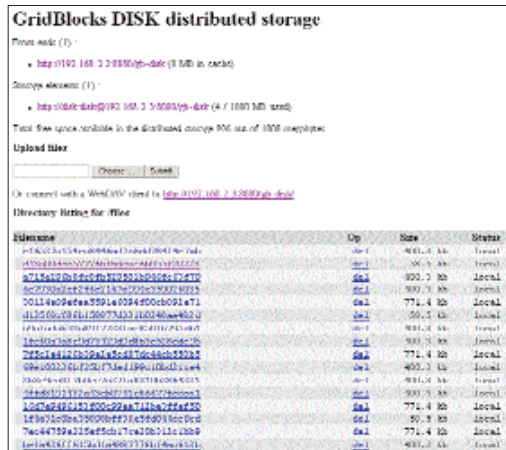




The Front End, as seen through your web browser



What happens to your files in the Storage Elements

To start the SE, use this command:

```
java -jar gb-disk-se-0.8.1.jar
```

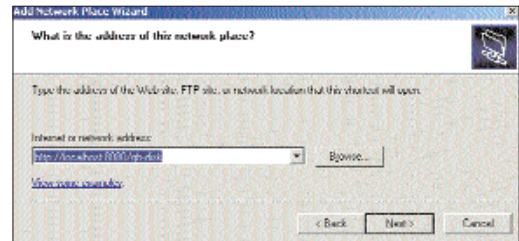
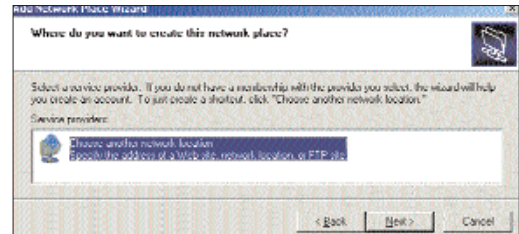
You will want to set up multiple Storage Elements—certainly more than Front Ends—this way, you can have some machines dedicated to the task of storage, rather than having to manage storage and the interface.

Once you're done setting up Front Ends and Storage Elements, you can start using the grid. You can either use a browser, or set up a Web folder. To use your browser, just navigate to <http://IP Address of Front End:8080/gb-disk>.

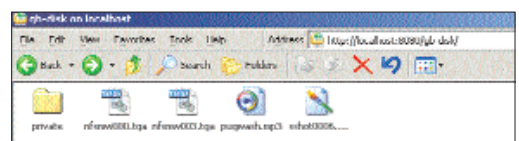
Using this interface, you can now choose the files you want to upload to the grid. To see the fate of your files, you can use the above address and replace the IP address of the Front End with the IP address of a Storage Element. What you will see is a bunch of incoherent file names that actually represent the fragments of the files you uploaded through the Front End.

If you would prefer not to use the browser and have it look more like the familiar Windows folders, you can set up a Web Folder—GridBlocks supports the WebDAV protocol (see box *WebDAV*) and will let you do this. Just open My Network Places and select Add Network Place. When asked where you would like this network place to be created, select "Choose another Network Location" and click Next. In the Internet address field that comes up, use the aforementioned address. You can now view the contents of the storage grid in a transparent folder-like environment.

Finally, if you're feeling particularly geeky, you can use the



Setting up the Web Folder



Ah, the comfy world of Explorer-like folders

command line to manage files on the grid. Using the command prompt, navigate to the folder with the GridBlocks .jar files and use the following command:

```
java -jar gb-disk-0.8.1.jar [put/get/delete/exists] [file name] [FE URL]
```

Adding more machines to the grid is as easy as can be—just launch the SE service. Launching the Storage Element service automatically sends out a message to all the other machines, effectively saying, "Hey, I'm here to share the load too!"

Nearly There

With all this capability, and completely free to boot, you would probably want to embrace GB-DISK with open arms right about now. Be warned, though—it is not without its limitations. Firstly, support for subdirectories is shaky, and you will most likely encounter failure messages if you try uploading folders.

Secondly, while it does support authenticating users to have their own private folders (you will find a "private" folder through the front end), this feature is buggy at best and not recommended for use.

Finally, with a dearth of proper documentation, configuring GB-DISK can be quite the pain in the hindquarter area.

All this aside, if what you're looking for is a place to dump files where they will be available almost perpetually—even after failures of one or more machines—this is the solution for you.

On the bright side, the GridBlocks team seem to be working night and day to perfect their program. Scarcely had we finished bundling version 0.8 of the software on the DVD than they came up with version 0.9! You can track their progress at <http://gridblocks.sourceforge.net>.

nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com